

M7T2: Sustaining Habits Post-Course — 10 min

Video File M7T2-Habits.mp4 (habit loop diagram) · **Resources** Habit Log.pdf (habit loop worksheet, three-habit tracker, accountability page, relapse plan) · **Xp** 70 total · Choose 3 Habits 40 · Track with Log 30

Target runtime 10 min · 1,136 spoken words · ≈ 7.6 min at 150 wpm · ≈ 8.4 min at a warm 135 wpm

0:00–0:30 **HOOK**

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera.]

Here's a fact about willpower that will set you free: nobody has enough of it. Not me, not you, not the people who seem to. The people who keep habits aren't stronger; they've arranged their lives so that the habit is the easy thing. Today I'll show you the science of that arrangement, and how to protect it against the two things most likely to break it: a craving and a bad week.

0:30–3:30 **THE SCIENCE: LOOPS, NOT WILLPOWER**

[VISUAL: Habit loop diagram: Cue → Routine → Reward, then the four-step version: Cue → Craving → Response → Reward.]

Charles Duhigg, in *The Power of Habit*, popularized the loop that habit researchers had described: a cue, a routine, and a reward. James Clear, in *Atomic Habits*, added a fourth step: cue, craving, response, reward. The cue is the trigger: the time, the place, the feeling. The craving is the wanting the cue

sets off. The response is what you do. The reward is what you get, which teaches the brain to do it again next time the cue appears. Every habit you've built in this course runs on this loop, and so does every habit you're trying to leave behind. The nine-o'clock pantry visit from Module One is a loop. So is the morning glass of water. The loop doesn't care which one it's running.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Lally, 2010: median 66 days to automaticity; one missed day made no difference."]

Two findings to keep. Phillippa Lally's study found that habits became automatic after a median of sixty-six days, with a wide range, and that missing a single day made no measurable difference to the long-term outcome. And BJ Fogg's research at Stanford, in *Tiny Habits*, found that the size of the habit matters less than the anchor and the celebration: a habit tied to an existing routine and followed by a moment of genuine satisfaction sticks far better than a bigger habit done on willpower.

So the four levers of a lasting habit are: make the cue obvious, make the response easy, make the reward immediate, and make the whole thing tiny enough to do on your worst day.

Notice that "reward" in the loop doesn't mean a treat. For the morning glass of water, the reward is the feeling of having started the day well, and Fogg's celebration, the small "yes," is how you make sure the brain registers it. For the walk, it's the calm afterward. For the check-in, it's the closeness. Every keeper habit in this course already carries its own reward; the celebration just makes sure it's noticed before you move on to the next thing. That's the difference between a habit that feels like a chore and one that feels like a gift you keep giving yourself.

3:30–8:30 STRATEGIES

[VISUAL: Slide: "Choose three. Not fifteen. Three."]

Strategy one: choose three. Your plan from Training One has fifteen habits. For the Habit Log, pick the three that matter most and are least automatic; the ones you'd lose first in a bad week. Those three get daily tracking for the next month. The other twelve are on the plan, but the log is for the three that need it. Trying to track fifteen is how people track none.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Anchor and stack."]

Strategy two: anchor and stack. Every one of your three gets an anchor, "after I pour my coffee," "when I get into bed," and where possible, stack them: the water after the coffee, the meditation after the water, so one cue starts a chain. Fogg calls this the recipe: "After I [anchor], I will [tiny habit], then I'll [celebrate]."

[VISUAL: Slide: "Accountability: a person, a place, a number."]

Strategy three: accountability. A person: your partner at the weekly check-in, or an accountability buddy from the forum, someone who gets the one-word "done" text. Research on implementation intentions by Milne, Orbell, and Sheeran in the British Journal of Health Psychology found that people who made specific when-and-where plans, and were followed up on, were dramatically more likely to exercise than those who were merely motivated. A place: the forum, where you post your log photo each Sunday. A number: the streak on the log, which is why the log has boxes and not just lines.

Apps can help, and I'm not against them; a habit app, a step counter, a sleep tracker, a cycle app. Two rules. Use one app, not five. And the app records the habit; it doesn't replace it. If

you'd rather use paper, the Habit Log is paper, and paper has one advantage: it doesn't ping you at eleven p.m.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Environment beats willpower: design the cue."]

Strategy four: design the environment, which this whole course has been quietly teaching. The pitcher on the counter, the shoes by the door, the phone in the kitchen, the sweets on the high shelf, the mat left rolled out. Every one of these makes the cue obvious and the response easy. When a habit fails, ask what the environment was telling you before you ask what your willpower was doing.

And the reverse: when a habit that used to be automatic starts failing, look for what changed in the environment. A new job that moved the coffee time. A house guest who put the sweets back on the counter. A season when the walk got dark and cold. The habit didn't weaken; the cue moved. Find the new cue, or rebuild the old one, and the habit usually returns within a week. The Habit Log has a column labeled "what changed" for exactly this, and it will save you from blaming yourself for what was really a moved kettle.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Relapse plan: the slip · the story · the reset."]

Now the relapse plan, and it's built on the work of Alan Marlatt, who studied why people who had changed a behavior fell back into it. His finding: it's rarely the slip itself. It's the story told about the slip. "I ate the cake, so I've failed, so I might as well eat the rest": Marlatt called it the abstinence violation effect, and Polivy and Herman's "what-the-hell effect" from Module Two is the same thing. The antidote is a plan written in advance, when you're calm, for the two most likely slips: a craving that wins, and a week that falls apart.

For the craving: "When I've eaten the thing, I'll say 'that was a slip, not a fall,' drink a glass of water, and do the next scheduled habit as if nothing happened." For the bad week: "When I've missed three days, I'll do the tiny version of all three habits, once, today, and text my accountability person the word 'reset.'" Write both in the Habit Log. A slip you've planned for is a slip that ends quickly.

Sustainability is grace-filled. Life will change, a pregnancy, a move, a job, a loss, and the plan will bend with it. Adjust as

life evolves toward conception. The only version of this that fails is the one that demands perfection.

9:30–10:00 ACTION HANDOFF

[VISUAL: End card: "Habit Log PDF → Choose 3 habits (40 XP) → Track them for the month (30 XP)."]

Download the Habit Log, choose your three habits and write their anchors, celebrations, and relapse plans for forty XP, and track them daily for thirty. Then meet me in Training Three: what to measure, what to ignore, and when to call a specialist.

ACTION CALLOUT

RESOURCE Habit Log.pdf (habit-loop worksheet, three-habit recipe cards, 4-week tracker, accountability page, relapse plans for cravings and bad weeks). **ACTION 1:** Choose three habits and write their recipes and relapse plans (40 XP). **ACTION 2:** Track them daily with the log (30 XP). **NEXT STEP:** Training 3 · Monitoring Progress and Adjustments.